



COURSE REPORT FOR FIRST CYCLE COURSES IN POLITICAL SCIENCE

The aim of the course report is to demonstrate responsiveness towards the students' views, guarantee the quality of the course, and stimulate subject-related and pedagogical development. The report should have a forward-looking focus and be based on the course coordinator's own reflections and input received from students (individually or in groups), teaching staff, education administrators, and the study counsellor, as well as the course evaluation.

Course name:	Institutional Development and Democratization in an International Perspective
Course code:	SK1227
Semester:	Autumn 2025 (HT25)
Course coordinator (name and e-mail address):	Nikolay Marinov (nikolay.marinov@gu.se)
Brief description of course content and structure	This course deals with the origins of the state, problems of autocratic rule, the emergence and advantages of democracy, how democracy influences autocracy and vice versa, and what the future might hold.
Completion rate and grades	36 students registered for the course (including 1 dropout). Number of students with final grades: 35 Of whom with a G: 9; Of whom with a VG: 26. 23 students (63.89%) responded to the course evaluation. The course was generally perceived as balanced in workload, with the large majority of students considering it "OK" (60.9%) or not that demanding (39.1%). A few students noted that the workload intensified toward the end of the course, particularly in connection with the final exam.



General and specific impressions of the course	Students found the course interesting, relevant, and rewarding, with many describing it as one of the best they had taken. The focus on often-overlooked cases (e.g., Georgia, Bulgaria) and current events was particularly appreciated. The combination of discussion sessions, literature, and cycle structure was highlighted positively, though several students noted that lectures sometimes felt detached from the literature and lacked clear scientific grounding or structure. Overall, the course received very positive feedback.
Students' general impressions of the course	Students appreciated the engaging content, relevant literature, and interactive seminars. Many reported being motivated to complete all readings. The teacher's personal and encouraging style was frequently praised. Some students suggested the course still has potential for further development as it is relatively new (second iteration). "A fun and interesting course." "One of the best (if not the best) course I've taken so far." "Interesting subjects throughout the course... I have learned a lot."



Students' impressions of specific elements of the course	Literature: Very positive (mean 1.6). Students liked the mix of academic texts, articles, and books. Some found certain readings (e.g., Sacred Foundations) less well integrated. The amount of reading was generally seen as appropriate, allowing deeper engagement. Lectures and seminars: Generally positive (mean 1.9), with seminars highly valued for fostering discussion. Lectures were described as interesting but often unstructured, making note-taking difficult. Students suggested more cohesive presentation, clearer links to literature/assignments, and occasional videos. Examinations: Positive overall (mean 1.8). Assignments were appreciated for their interesting topics and freedom of reasoning, though clearer instructions upfront were requested. Some concerns were raised about the final exam's clarity, preparation materials, and last-minute changes. Teachers: Excellent feedback (mean 1.2). Nikolay was praised as knowledgeable, engaging, encouraging, and supportive. Students valued real-life examples and the non-strict atmosphere. Organization/Canvas: Mixed (mean 2.3). Positive aspects included regular scheduling and good communication from the teacher. Criticisms focused on changing readings/assignments, information scattered across Canvas, and late clarifications.
Impression of any epiphany moments that the students have experienced during the course	A majority (60.9%) reported eye-opening experiences. Students highlighted learning about authoritarian backsliding in Eastern Europe (especially Bulgaria), different country perspectives in seminars, the complexity of global politics, threats to democracy, and the weight of political decisions. Many appreciated gaining insights into countries rarely covered in Swedish media and different theoretical viewpoints. "The situation in Bulgaria was a real eye opener." "The readings and lectures about backsliding, Ur-Fascism and the threats to democracies really widened my view." "Decisions, decisions, decisions." (on EU actions and perspective-taking)



Impressions of students' and teachers' views on the administration of the course, incl. Canvas	Organization improved compared to the first iteration but still received the most criticism. Students appreciated the cycle format and regular schedule but pointed to too many last-minute changes to readings, assignments, and exam information. Information was sometimes scattered between announcements and modules, and clearer upfront guidelines were requested. Several students noted that the course is still evolving.
Ideas of potential changes for the next round	• Strengthen structure and cohesion in lectures (clearer PowerPoints, better links to literature and assignments). • Provide stable, early information about assignments, exam format, and readings. • Further integrate different course elements (lectures–seminars–assignments). • Consider more consistent note-taking support and occasional varied formats (e.g., short videos). • Finalize materials before the course starts to reduce changes during the term.
Ideas of long-term and/or more comprehensive changes	Continue developing the course structure and integration of components while preserving the strong elements: engaging teacher style, high-quality literature selection, interactive seminars, and focus on under-covered international cases. Further international perspectives (beyond Europe) could be considered where relevant.
Other comments	Students expressed strong overall appreciation for the course and the teacher despite areas needing improvement. Many would recommend the course. Nikolay was repeatedly described as competent, passionate, personal, and supportive. “I really like our teacher... it made me feel more at ease.” “Thanks you M. Marinov.” “I would really recommend this course.”
From the course evaluation question: “Overall, how do you assess the course?”	



	VT25	HT25	VT26	HT26	VT27	HT27	
	1.6	1.6					
	Means						

Note: The survey question was rated on a 1–5 scale, where 1 is best and 5 is worst (Very good = 1). Distribution of responses (HT25, n=23): 1 = Very good ($n = 11$, 47.8%), 2 = Rather good ($n = 11$, 47.8%), 3 = Neither good nor bad ($n = 1$, 4.3%), 4/5 = 0. The mean score remained stable at 1.6.